



Fibromyalgia



Pain



Disability



Health



Life



It is not all in the head: Fibromyalgia is real!

For many of us, the journey to acceptance is a gradual process. This is my story — of diagnosis, pain, and ultimately, acceptance.

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We will bloom, with pain or without!

The early signs

At 6:30 in the morning, my father received a call in June 2020, inquiring about my name. Taking the phone, I encountered a man on the other end in a state of frantic

distress. Despite his emotional urgency, I struggled to comprehend his words. He gathered himself and informed me that his younger brother needed an oxygen cylinder and was in severe condition. I started making calls and going through my WhatsApp leads and groups. Having been 3 hours on the phone, I started taking help and eventually, more than 10 volunteers tried hard to find one. I spoke to that man at least 5–6 times during the day but could not find anything. Finally, at around 9 PM in the night, after more than 14 hours one of my teammates secured an oxygen cylinder and was about to leave for the man's house.

I, in my excitement, called the man to inform him it had been done! I called, only to listen to people crying at the other end...

My shoulders dropped, it seemed something was burning inside my shoulders. I was in extreme pain. During the day, I was on more than 200 calls to coordinate the relief work. It was during this time my pain started. It seemed it was because of too much use of my phone, and I kept going. Post 3 months, in Aug 2020, I visited the first orthopaedic who prescribed some medications. I realised it has been many months of coordinating, delivering ration kits, listening to people, and leading a team and I have been in pain all that time. But I ignored my body. I ignored its communication with me.

Over the following six months, I engaged in numerous consultations, underwent various rounds of blood tests, took supplements, relied on painkillers, and endured countless physiotherapy sessions. Despite these efforts, the pain persisted relentlessly. My ability to move, engage in activities, and lead a normal life became increasingly constrained, while the intensity of the pain continued to escalate day by day.

Deepening of pain

In April 2021 we were struck by the second wave of covid-19. I was in a lot of pain but again plunged into relief work. This time, things were different. I would be in constant discomfort even while using my mobile, brushing my teeth, and wearing clothes. I would do COVID relief work during the day and be in bed in the evening, to only get up the next morning, to be in debilitating mind-numbing pain in bed to only resume calls at 8 in the morning. I was not listening to my body. Gradually, the time I spent on calls for relief shortened, and the time I would spend in bed increased. I continued like this for months to be in bed in pain for 17–18 hours just to ensure I would make calls for the rest of the day.

As the lockdown eased, and we returned to work I started carrying a shoulder sling. Being at work for 8 hours was difficult and I had to resort to lying down for a couple of hours. I started taking leaves, half days, and breaks — all to ensure my body restores.

It's not all in the head

Around 15 months later, a doctor diagnosed me with Fibromyalgia.

My diagnosis took place nearly 2 years after I started experiencing pain and it took me another year to accept it. Before that, the blood tests and X-rays showed nothing, and yet I was still in pain. Senior doctors in the city would negate my claim of being in deep agony. They would often say I was too young to be in this kind of pain. A close friend, one day seriously asked 'Do you really have pain, or do you just feel you have pain?'

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The doctors were puzzled and I was frustrated. It was as if the burden of proof of my pain was constantly put on me, while what was failing was our medical diagnostic system. It seemed I had to fight, fight for people to acknowledge my challenges.

Fibromyalgia, as such, forces people to think the pain is not real after all there is no proof. But isn't one's voice far greater proof than modern diagnostic methods?

A therapist said that COVID relief work was akin to post-war trauma, of seeing deaths, absorbing grief, and still trying to function. It is not just the mind and heart, but the body too stores emotions and responds to them. Mine too was responding. It was as if the trauma was always stored, the covid-19 pandemic surfaced and brought it out in the open.

Pain management

I initially thought to write an article titled "Fibromyalgia: 101", and write all symptoms, write everything that works and anything that does not. The truth is, it is

unique to everyone and I still am learning.

But with 3 years of chronic pain and finding acceptance, here are things that worked for me:

1. Acceptance — It seemed that the pain of living with uncertainty was greater than my actual pain. I kept on running from one doctor to another in search of a “cure”. I could not accept I could have a lifelong condition that would limit my mobility.
2. An accessible workplace — I keep on thinking about this that I would have been fired from any regular job, for not being productive. Workplace accessibility for persons with disabilities is a huge challenge. For me, my workplace became my strength. I was given no questions asked leaves, I would go in late, get out early, choose not to travel, and choose to lie down right in the middle of the office. They were not just with me, but they made me who I am.
3. Listening to one’s body — I identified my triggers and what escalated my pain. With fibromyalgia, each day is different. I gradually figured I couldn’t give in to my pain and have to try and do things. I say no to things, cancel plans at the last moment, and try not to push my body.
4. Self-care — It was finally a small quaint town in Uttarakhand that initiated my healing journey. I have utmost gratitude for my friends and family for enabling me to try and a break from fighting my pain was beneficial. I also explored yoga, meditation, journaling, and body emotions — all in the quest to find out what works for me. I am still experimenting but now have a deeper connection with my body.

In the year 2023, I tried swimming, went to the gym, and traveled to 5 different cities.

Finally, openly talking about it has been a crucial cog in this healing process. I feel every time I talk and write about it, I let the rays of acceptance inside me and move an inch toward healing. I have learned how my body responds and although it can't change, I am more mindful of the body’s reaction to my emotions. Easy stretching exercises, short breaks, and openly talking about it have let me believe it's going to be okay. It is often an isolating journey, but not a lonely one.



I have been able to do what I love — to sow and sow!

The love, care, and affection I have received throughout this has made me deeply grateful for life!

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.
